

Eating meat is 15 times worse for the environment than a person talking to an AI for 3 hours a day. Anyone care to explain why anti-ai "ecowarriors" only talk about one of those?

Posted by u/Dry_Incident6424 • • 0 points • 105 comments

Just to be clear here, the environmental impact of personal AI use is minuscule. Switching from a meat diet to a plant based diet would cut about a ton of CO2 admissions from your lifestyle a year. Cutting 3 hours of heavy AI use per day would cut about 0.05 tons from your climate impact. Yes, AI produces greenhouse gasses, it's actual minuscule compared to other hobbies and habits.

A 10 mile round trip drive 3 times a week to go to lake to go fishing produces roughly 10 times the greenhouse gasses heavy daily AI use consumes.

I'm not saying you have to stop eating meat or stop driving to engage in your hobbies. I'm saying the "AI is bad for the environment" argument makes you a massive hypocrite when you have other habits that are objectively way worse for the environment than personal AI use. You're not actually caring about the environment, you're just using it a cudgel to attack something you don't like, which is super lame. Yes two things can be bad a once. Still it makes you a hypocrite if you claim to care about something, but only focus one thing which is way less of a big deal.

Climate change is a serious issue and deserves to be taken seriously. Blaming AI for climate change and making anyone who uses AI feel bad about it is comical.

Let me really drive home that eating meat is way worse than AI for the planet, how much worse?

If every human on the planet went vegetarian, it would eliminate about 15 billion tons of CO2 emissions per year. The entire AI industry produces about 100 million tons of CO2 per year on the high end. The AI industry would need grow at least 100X to do the same damage to the environment that eating meat does today. To be clear here, we're calculating this by replacing meat consumption with other types of food.

Again, if you want to eat meat, I can't stop you. That is your right, but please never ever

lecture me about how bad AI is for the environment while eating a hamburger.

Yes, I'm fully aware that I have become the final boss of annoying internet arguments "The angry pro-ai vegetarian", but the fact is, I'm right.

Comments

u/TheRenaissanceMaker • 1 points • 2026-03-11 15:33 UTC

Owr ancestors weren't vegan

u/Atlanos043 • 1 points • 2026-03-10 15:15 UTC

It simply adds.

Now I am fully aware I'm a hypocrite because I eat meat (though I am also not one of those people who NEED meat each day and I fully support "lab meat" assuming it's more environmentally friendly, also for what it's worth I don't have a car and haven't gone by plane since pre-COVID), but for me it's exactly BECAUSE all of the things that are mentioned. I adds another environmental problem to the already existing environmental problems.

u/clairegcoleman • 1 points • 2026-03-10 06:21 UTC

Blah blah vegan lies blah blah vegan propaganda blah blah.

u/Bourriquet_42 • 1 points • 2026-03-10 04:43 UTC

But AI energy usage grows exponentially. And it needs to keep growing exponentially for it to improve (linearly), which every pro-ai happily says WILL happen. If we were all saying "ok, AI is done, this is the final product", I would kind of agree with you.

u/Dry_Incident6424 • 1 points • 2026-03-10 04:46 UTC

AI growth isn't linear with power consumption. Models of today are actually more efficient than older models.

Old opus models are actually more expensive to run than newer ones.

Obvious the total size of the industry may grow, but the impact of a single user might go up go down or stay flat. We don't know yet.

u/Bourriquet_42 • 1 points • 2026-03-10 12:21 UTC

Any data on these efficiency gains? I can't find much besides corporate sales bs with vague language. Hardware efficiency gains have always been pretty marginal. That would be irrational to believe it can compensate the exponential growth of all other parameters.

u/Dry_Incident6424 • 1 points • 2026-03-10 15:46 UTC

The answer is they're getting more efficient and it's not even close.
Scaling compute is more than matched by scaling efficiency.

<https://arxiv.org/pdf/2511.23455>

u/JakeBanana01 • 1 points • 2026-03-10 02:48 UTC

Where did you get your these figures?

u/Dry_Incident6424 • 1 points • 2026-03-10 03:06 UTC

Sources

The Carbon Cost: Quitting Meat vs. Quitting AI

Cutting meat (per person, per year):

- Meat-heavy diet: ~ 2.6 tons CO₂e/year
- Vegetarian diet: ~ 1.4 tons CO₂e/year
- Savings: ~ 1.2 tons CO₂e/year

Sources: Poore & Nemecek, "Reducing food's environmental impacts through producers and consumers," Science (2018) — largest meta-analysis of global food systems. Oxford University summary: <https://www.ox.ac.uk/news/2018-06-01-new-estimates-environmental-cost-food>

Cutting 3 hours/day of AI conversation:

- Energy per query ranges from 0.3 Wh (Epoch AI, 2025) to 18.9 Wh (University of Rhode Island, 2025)
- Using a middle estimate of 5 Wh $\times$ 80 queries/day = 146 kWh/year
- At US grid average of 0.64 kg CO₂/kWh (EPA eGRID, 2024)
- Total: ~ 93 kg CO₂e/year = 0.093 tons

Sources:

- Epoch AI: <https://epoch.ai/gradient-updates/how-much-energy-does-chatgpt-use>
- EPA eGRID: <https://www.epa.gov/egrid>
- EIA grid emissions: <https://www.eia.gov/tools/faqs/faq.php?id=74&t=11>

Cutting meat saves 13x more CO₂ than a heavy AI user quitting AI entirely.

Even using the highest per-query estimate (18.9 Wh), AI use tops out at ~ 0.35 tons/year — still 3.4x less than meat.

For scale: the entire global AI industry emits ~50-100 million tons CO2e/year. The global livestock industry emits ~7.1 billion tons (FAO, 2023). Livestock would need to shrink by 98.5% before AI was the bigger problem.

Source: FAO, "Tackling Climate Change Through Livestock" —
<http://www.fao.org/3/i3437e/i3437e.pdf>

u/JakeBanana01 • 1 points • 2026-03-10 03:09 UTC

Thanks for sharing; I don't like to blindly trust stats quoted in a Reddit post.

u/Dry_Incident6424 • 2 points • 2026-03-10 03:20 UTC

Smart, anyone can put anything on reddit.

u/lootedBacon • 2 points • 2026-03-11 16:41 UTC

Now they just need to actually read it.

u/PresentationAny1221 • 0 points • 2026-03-10 01:50 UTC

Comparing eating food, a biological need, to talking to a chatbot is a really dumb thing to say

u/Dry_Incident6424 • 0 points • 2026-03-10 02:01 UTC

You biologically need to eat, you don't biologically need meat my dude.

u/TroubleOk9761 • 2 points • 2026-03-10 00:07 UTC

Just eat children duhh

u/Dry_Incident6424 • 2 points • 2026-03-10 00:08 UTC

If you eat a person who eats meat, then the total amount of meat consumption has gone down.
It's not only a moral good, it's a moral imperative.